



IMAGE MANAGEMENT

For those who only occasionally snap images and have only about a hundred images to manage, the image management in Windows XP should be sufficient. Most cameras come bundled with basic image management software, but these just let you browse through your pictures, and arrange them in different folders, but not much else. The real problem of image management arises when you have thousands of images.

Photoshop Album is a comprehensive image management software. Ease of use is written all over the software. There are a few features that help this software beat the crowd easily—the timeline shows the dates at which images were taken, and small bars indicate how many images were clicked in that month or on that date. This is useful if you want to search for an image, and you can remember only the month you shot it in.

The second feature that makes Photoshop Album stand tall is the various ways you can use images with it. You can create greeting cards, calendars and photo books, and even embed audio into all of these.

Adobe Photoshop Album

- + Friendly interface, timeline show, Creation Wizard, 3D virtual rooms
- Long boot up time, creations can be saved only as PDF files

Price: \$49.99

Web site:
www.adobe.com

Reviewed In:
September 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: Adobe Photoshop 7
2001: Adobe Photoshop 6.01

The Creation Wizard makes the whole process a breeze.

A unique feature is that you can search for an image that is visually similar to another. You can also create 3D virtual rooms with your images on the walls, and take a 3D tour of the room.

However, Photoshop Album does have

WORTHY MENTIONS

Ulead Photo Explorer 8.0

- + Standalone viewer, image editor is impressive, CD catalogue feature
- Searching not up to the mark

Price: \$29.95

Web site: www.ulead.com
Reviewed In: September 2003

Picasa 1.0

- + Exclude duplicates, clubbing of images, dynamic timeline
- Limited effects

Price: \$29.99

Web site: http://www.lifescapeinc.com
Reviewed In: September 2003

its share of woes. You cannot select multiple images by clicking and dragging the mouse over them, as in Windows Explorer. Also, the program only offers basic image editing features, and you cannot add any special effects to the images. Despite these limitations, Photoshop Album's user-friendliness and features make it an attractive buy for home users.

LINUX (OFFICE DESKTOP)

SUSE Linux distributions have always been very promising, and the release of this office desktop indicates an attempt to break up the distros into two distinct categories—one targeted at the general user, and the other at the office user.

Installing the SuSE Office Desktop is similar to installing any of the standard SuSE distros. The interface is very simple for those who have had some previous experience with SuSE, but for the newbie it can get confusing—SuSE does not follow the step-by-step installation process that is used by all the other distros. Instead, it uses a format that is similar to a Web page—all detected settings are displayed on a single screen. To change any of the settings you need to click on the specific item on the listing. The problem with this kind of installation is that the user might miss out an important setting that should have been changed. Otherwise, the install is perfect. The default option provided in the installation mounted all existing Windows partitions by itself.

SuSE Linux Office Desktop

- + Auto mounts Windows partitions, Crossover bundled
- Does not follow the step-by-step installation process, can't install from source code

Price: Euro 120.60

Web site: www.suse.de/en/

Reviewed In:
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PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: NA
2001: NA

The hardware support is quite amazing; it didn't have problems installing on any of the testbeds. The SuSE Office Desktop really stands up to its name when it comes to scaling up for the office user. Apart from the bundled StarOffice 6.0 it comes with Crossover, which lets you run many Windows-based applications on Linux.

WORTHY MENTIONS

Red Hat Linux 9.0

- + Very well documented online as well as offline, excellent configuration tools provided
- High system load

Price: Free

Web site: www.redhat.com
Reviewed In: August 2003

Mandrake Linux 9.1 Standard

- + Control Centre is an excellent tool, Software Sources Manager makes the update process a lot easier
- Has problems accessing Windows shares across the network

Price: \$39.90

Web site: www.mandrakelinux.com
Reviewed In: August 2003

Compatibility with rpm packages was not a problem. This distribution does not come with a 'make' utility, or any compilers. All installations have to be done from binary packages—bad for advanced users, but quite fine for novices.